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Source: *Annals of the Association of American Geographers*, Vol. 82, No. 1 (Mar., 1992), pp. 117-135

Published by: Taylor & Francis, Ltd. on behalf of the Association of American Geographers

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/2563539>

Accessed: 15-08-2019 14:42 UTC

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Television as Gathering Place

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Abstract. An examination of television as a center of meaning and as a social context supports the concept of a place without a location. Similar ideas have appeared in media theory since the 1960s, but have not been the subject of geographic research. Comparison of television with other media, including books, radio, and film, reveals that it is uniquely place-like. Television functions as a social context, providing sensory communion and social congregation; it also functions as a center of meaning, helping a society define "us" and "them," conferring value on persons and objects, and, possibly, supporting hegemonic social control. A comparison of television and certain architectural structures identifies similarities and differences that may be related to long-term historical changes in society.

Key Words: place, television, modernity, media, consumption, ideology.

Every activity generates a particular spatio-temporal structure (Tuan 1977, 130–31).

THE expression "television as place" can convey both the vernacular meaning of television as escape and the academic media-theory idea of television as environment. In this essay I will compare television with other media and with actual places that allow people to gather and/or share experiences. My purpose is not to argue that television is a place in the conventional geographical sense, but rather to examine the many similarities between television and human-made places and to shed light on the cultural-geographic implications of watching television. My excursion beyond the traditional geographic definition of "place" is intended to define rather than to explain. The adequacy of this attempt should be determined on the basis of utility rather than "truth."

It is necessary to examine, first, what is meant by "place" and by "television," and how

media theorists have connected both terms; then, how geographers have understood modern communication technologies and some problems inherent in calling television a place. The other main sections of the paper will discuss television as a social context and television as a center of meaning.

Background and Prospects

Three Conceptions of Place

Place can be defined in various ways. A river system is a place, as is a market system, and a university. The first example illustrates a conception based on physical processes, the second on societal integration, and the third on the construction of meaning. Vernacular speech and unscientific thought take this triadic division to an extreme. People will say: "I was at a very bad place in my life" (i.e., a crisis of meaning), "school was the right place for me in my early twenties" (i.e., social context), and "my glasses weren't in any of the places I looked" (i.e., locations in the physical world). I will refer to these conceptions of place later in the paper as "center of meaning," "social context" (or simply "context"), and "physical place."¹ Geographers have been reluctant to employ "place" with this degree of variation, perhaps because they are unusually sensitive to place's unique ability to integrate physical, social, and ideological systems (Hartshorne 1949; Sack 1988, 1989). Nevertheless, geographers often consider certain components of a place in isolation. A physical geographer may study a mountain range with little reference to the impact of humans on the land; an economic geographer may study a city with no interest in either the rock strata underlying it or the values and experiences of the city's inhabitants; and a humanist geographer may study the ways a place is given meaning with little concern for

the relation of a place's meaning to economic and political structures, or a place's climate and topography.

Discussion of place as pure meaning is almost absent in geographic literature. A geographer might mention being at a "difficult place" in her/his research, but she/he would not consider studying that "place" geographically. Similarly, though an urban geographer might define a city in terms of its inhabitants' characteristics such as median age and income, he/she would not see the city itself as expanding and contracting each day with the ebb and flow of commuters, or moving to another place if its inhabitants are evacuated. To a geographer, "place" ultimately means a bounded region on the earth's surface, regardless of what other meanings it may hold. In short, the definition of place remains tied to location, rather than purely to meaning or social relations.

While there may be many reasons to maintain location as the minimal criterion of place, it may also be necessary for geographers to study place-like phenomena in the realms of meaning or social relations that are not ultimately tied to locations. The idea of "television as place" adopted here refers to (1) a bounded system in which symbolic interaction among persons occurs (a social context), and (2) a nucleus around which ideas, values, and shared experiences are constructed (a center of meaning). It is obvious that these two conceptions of place are closely related: social life is founded on shared meanings and meanings are created through social life; each constructs the other (Giddens 1984, 170, 264). Examples of television's role as a social context include its involvement in elections, celebrations, and competitions; tuning in to key events such as the Olympics is, among other things, a way of joining a crowd. Examples of television's role as a center of meaning include the popularization of commercial slogans, fashions, attitudes and values. These meanings interact with culture, become amazingly ubiquitous, and resonate in unpredictable ways. (Here and throughout I wish to discourage notions of a simple, deterministic, cause-effect relationship between television and social life.) Just as place integrates both social relations and meaning, my discussions of television as social context and as center of meaning will be interrelated. The division marks a

shift in emphasis, not a rigid separation. There are indeed many other characteristics of place not found in television which also demand attention from social scientists, and many ways in which the terms "world" and "environment" come closer to expressing the nature of television.

Television Use

The sheer prominence of television in daily life has an influence on social processes and the use of places. Gross statistics on time use suggest perhaps a greater role for television than is actually the case, since attention to the television set varies in actual viewing situations, and performing various activities while watching television is the norm. Nevertheless, these data are important to geographers, because the more time people spend watching television, the less time they can spend in public places such as sports arenas, churches, markets, and squares (Hawley 1986, 101).

Watching television is the greatest single use of "free time" (time not spent working, sleeping, or attending to household or personal needs) not only in post-industrial societies such as the U.S., but also in industrial and many preindustrial societies (Szalai 1972, ch. 6; Lull 1988; "Television in the Developing World" 1985). In the U.S., the average person spends 40 percent of his/her free time attending to television at some level (Robinson and Converse 1972). The average American family's television set is turned on for about six hours per day. Ninety-eight percent of all households have television sets and 76 percent of the total population watches television on a given night during prime time (U.S. Bureau of the Census 1990). At the current rate of growth, there will be an average of two televisions per U.S. household in 1995.

The appeal of the medium transcends national borders. In a major international study, the principal determinant of viewing time was television ownership (Robinson and Converse 1972, 198). Other factors such as education and class had varying effects. In general, once people are able to acquire a television set, they use it with similar alacrity whether they live in Des Moines, Iowa or Kragujevac, Yugoslavia.

Television in Media Theory

Current media theory stems from two main traditions. The tradition dominant in North America from the 1950s through the mid-1980s looks mainly at supposed psychological and social effects of television on society. In this case, whether television is viewed as a technology or as a mode of communication, the dominant causality is from television to society. Such work ranges from the empirical (e.g., work of George Gerbner and his associates) to the theoretical (e.g., work of Marshall McLuhan and Neil Postman). The European media theory tradition partly contradicts, partly complements the North American approach. It draws on cultural materialism, linguistics, and semiotics to attempt to understand how television emerged from and works to reinforce existing structures and practices in society. This stance was most eloquently articulated by Raymond Williams, who sees television as a product of culture rather than vice-versa. "In a host of ways, following an already defined need, the means of transmitting still pictures and moving pictures were actively sought and to a considerable extent discovered" (1974, 17). Both paradigms can provide valuable contributions to the understanding of television. Culture and television are clearly involved in reciprocal relations: television affects culture, but culture also affects television in regard to interpretative strategies and social attitudes toward viewing.

There is a growing awareness in media theory that television is not a single phenomenon, but rather a set of phenomena. Ethnographers have found important differences among cultural groups in attitudes about watching TV and the social practices that develop around the act of viewing (see Newton and Buck 1985; Morley 1986, 1988; Liebes and Katz 1988; Lull 1988). There are also cross-cultural differences in the meaning of the television set, as both an object and a bearer of symbols (Leal 1988; Granzberg 1985; Salomon 1985). In studies of several cultures, significant differences were found in viewing attitudes and time use between men and women (T.M. Williams 1985) and among age groups (Altegott 1988). Even among families in the same cultural group, e.g., middle class, white, protestant, Americans, there can be significant differences in how television is incorporated into

daily life (Bryce 1987; Brody and Stoneman 1983; Fiske 1987). These differences have only begun to be explored, and geographers can play an important role in this research. Ethnographic studies such as these reflect European media studies by showing that television is incorporated into cultural practices and existing meaning systems. But they also reflect the North American tradition by illuminating how television can affect people's actions in families, tribes, and ethnic communities. Thus, ethnographic studies indicate some convergence of North American and European perspectives, but are only enlightening in regards to families and small groups.

There is not yet an integrative approach on the societal scale. Thinking of television (and perhaps other media) as a gathering place for vast numbers of people begins to fulfill this role. Traditional geographical conceptions of place employ an interactive model of human-environment interaction, with human actions shaping places and places in turn shaping actions (a view particularly characteristic of the Sauerian tradition). If television can be considered a place, insofar as people experientially inhabit it and relate to other persons through it or with it, then geographers may be able to provide some unique insights into television.

Media as an Environment, and Related Conceptions

Cutting across the traditional divisions of media theory outlined above is a tendency for media theorists to use terms such as "environment," "world," "place," and "space" to describe mass media. Though often used imprecisely and in ways which do not conform to geographic usage, these terms have reappeared with remarkable persistence throughout the past twenty-five years. What is meant by these terms can be most closely approximated by "place" or "world" in the geographical lexicon. Somewhat confusingly, media theorists use "environment" more often than either of these terms. Neil Postman defined a medium as "the social and intellectual environment a machine creates" (Postman 1985, 84). Four out of six articles in a recent edition of *Communication Research* contained the term "media environment" in their title, abstract, or major section headings (Dorr and

Kunkel 1990; Wartella et al. 1990; Brown et al. 1990; Morgan et al. 1990). Brown et al. (1990, 66) write: "Substantial numbers of [adolescents with working mothers] come home from school in the afternoon to empty houses and increasingly rich media environments." A sample of other common terms includes: "information environment," "television environment," and "environment of symbols," (see Schwartz 1973, 44; Barnouw 1978, 4; and Goethals 1981, 142, respectively). Anthropologist Edmund Carpenter was unusually explicit in his claim that "Media are really environments, with all the effects geographers [and] biologists associate with environments. We live inside our media" (1973, 63).

"World" has also been used, perhaps in ways more familiar to geographers. Eric Barnouw called television "a bright world in the middle of the home" (1978, 155); Ien Ang asserted that the program *Dallas* "has made its way into the experiential worlds of millions of viewers" (1985, 16), and Rubin et al. (1988, 108), concluded that "the more time people spend living in the world of television, the more similar their perceptions of social reality to television depictions."

The most famous (or perhaps infamous) media theorist, Marshall McLuhan, linked the use of television and other electronic media to the changing meaning of space, place, and time:

Electric circuitry has overthrown the regime of "time" and "space" and pours upon us instantly and continuously the concerns of all other men. It has reconstituted dialogue on a global scale. Its message is Total Change, ending psychic, social, economic, and political parochialism. The old civic, state, and national groupings have become unworkable. Nothing can be further from the spirit of the new technology than 'a place for everything and everything in its place.' You can't go home again (1967, 16).

McLuhan also coined the term "global village" to indicate the cultural unification he believed would be brought about by electronic media. Few have been as optimistic as McLuhan. In 1961 the chairman of the Federal Communications Commission (FCC), Newton Minow, made a now famous analogy—calling TV a "vast wasteland" (Esslin 1982, 103; Gitlin 1986, 3). Between technological utopianism and dystopianism lie less extreme images. Gary Gumpert claims that "When someone can be intimate with you [via electronic communication]

and yet be physically so far away, the concept of the geographical universe is altered. . . . Auditory and visual images can transcend time and space" (1987, 9).

An author strongly influenced by McLuhan, Joshua Meyrowitz, presents the most elaborate formulation of similar concepts. In *No Sense of Place*, Meyrowitz claims that: "Electronic media affect us . . . not primarily through their content, but by changing the 'situational geography' of social life" (1985, 6). He argues that television affects society most powerfully through a "blurring of many formerly distinct social roles" as television brings "many different types of people to the same 'place'" (1985, 6). "Place" is in quotes to indicate a separation in modern social life between social contexts, or "situations" (a term Meyrowitz borrows from Erving Goffman), and physical containers such as rooms and houses.

Well-established branches of social science have found terms that are central to geography to be powerful descriptors for television. The use of these terms is less important, in itself, than its implications: (1) that the phenomenon of *place* is no longer ultimately defined by location, and (2) that this state of affairs is, in part, a result of the use of electronic communication media. Herein lies a challenge to geography, particularly in light of the fact that existing geographic research has only begun to approach this issue.

Media Studies in Geography

Though no geographer has explored the idea that a medium might be a place in its own right,² many geographers recognize the importance of studying communication (Burgess and Gold 1985, ch. 1). The works of Janelle (1969, 1973), McDaniel (1975), Castells (1985), Huib and Jaeger (1989) and others, have indicated how patterns of communication are increasingly freed from the limitations of distance and physical obstacles to movement, but this body of work reveals mainly the role of telecommunication in commerce, industry, and regional development. The corresponding role of telecommunication in leisure has not yet been taken up in earnest.

Some of the earliest discussions of communication technologies in the geographic lit-

erature were in the spatial-analytic tradition. Since one of the key ideas in spatial analysis is the "friction of distance," transportation attracted attention early on as an agent of "spatial reorganization" (see Janelle 1969). Increased rapidity of transportation was seen as causing "time-space convergence" which could be measured as the rate of decrease in the time required to cover a given distance. Time-space convergence, in turn, brought about "spatial reorganization" most evident in the centralization and functional specialization of human settlements. These insights into the general effects of transportation were soon applied to communication technologies since communication and transportation could be taken together as "space altering technologies," i.e. means of facilitating "speedier, safer and more convenient movement of people, goods, raw materials and information" (Janelle 1973, 8). Janelle introduced an opposing process, time-space divergence, in his 1973 article. While convergence is the rule at large scales (interstate, international, global), divergence is prevalent in urban areas when infrastructure becomes overloaded and less efficient as a result of centralization and specialization. Further complexity is added by the idea of cost-space convergence/divergence, a measure of changes in the relative costs of long and short-distance travel and communication. Abler (1975a, 37) suggests unlimited possibilities along this line:

Spatial convergence can be measured for any distance-related cost or effort for which we can devise an appropriate scale. Thus, we can think of N spaces in which we might measure convergence and divergence. If we were clever enough, for example, we might be able to measure the convergence of metropolitan black and white neighborhoods in time-space and their simultaneous divergence in social-space.

This added insight does not merely indicate distortions in the isotropic spatial fabric, but suggests a world radically different from the one embodied in the original conceptions of spatial analysis.

Abler finds "complete time-space convergence" in North American communications systems—a situation in which there is no difference in the time required to communicate with near and far points (1975a, 40). From Melvin Webber, Abler adopts the concept that "nonplace communities" can exist, made up

of electronically communicating persons who are distributed through space. Though he posits a strange consequence of time-space convergence in personal communication, "[I]n time-space, all of North America is located at the same place" (p. 40), he also points out that differential access to mobility and communications, due to status and income, can lead to a social world split between nonplace communities and isolated, place-based ghettos of the underprivileged. In a similar vein, Wilbur Zelinsky mentions "A new geometry of cultural space" in which cultural groups dispersed through space can be visited "vicariously by means of telecommunications" (1973, 134).

Another course of investigation has addressed the experience of place in a world where mediated experience dominates direct experience. One of the first statements relating mass media to the experience of place is Edward Relph's denunciation of mass media in *Place and Placelessness*:

Mass media conveniently provide simplified and selective identities for places beyond the realm of immediate experience of the audience, and hence tend to fabricate a pseudo-world of pseudo-places. And someone exposed to these synthetic identities and stereotypes will almost inevitably be inclined to experience actual places in terms of them—a fact not missed by the developers of such real-life pseudo-places as Waikiki or Disneyland (1976, 58).

Relph draws connections between the perceptual character of first-hand experience and the distortions of second-hand experience. Recently there have been attempts by cultural geographers to define precisely what kinds of distortions characterize media portrayals of landscapes (for examples see Cosgrove 1984; Youngs 1985; Burgess 1985; Silk and Silk 1985; and Smith 1985). Distortions have been understood in these studies as systematic and integral to socioeconomic processes.

Along similar lines, geographers have studied television and film evocations of imaginary places, such as cities of the future (see Gold 1985, 1987) and their relation to present city-building processes. There has also been interest in the peculiar "language" of the television "text" (see Burgess 1987; Higson 1987) which underlies its ability to produce distorted images of places. Peter Gould and his col-

leagues have tried to find ways to categorize programs and quantify international program flows, with an underlying goal similar to that of Burgess and Higson, that is, to understand cultural hegemony. This work focuses on the "baggage of values [television carries] from one country and culture to another" (Gould and Lyew-Ayee 1985, 33; see also Gould et al. 1984; Janelle 1991; Lyew-Ayee 1991).

Kent MacDonald approaches the connection between television and place from a landscape studies tradition, by examining a landscape of consumption—the American strip—and how it reflects television advertising. He believes that television is responsible for the transformation in chain-store architecture from "gaudy and plastic" iconography (recall the old Jack-in-the-Box restaurants) to simulated ranch-style residential architecture (MacDonald 1985). While MacDonald emphasizes connections between modern culture and landscapes, Ley, in an analysis drawing from a broad field of literature, suggests that these connections are becoming weaker over time. He cites numerous claims that modern society has a void at the center—an absence of transcendent symbols which are universally and deeply accepted—and argues that this condition is reflected in modern culture and its meaningless landscapes. He quotes Canadian architect Arthur Erickson who refers to the modern city as "a profound charade that disguises momentarily the emptiness of our souls" (Ley 1989, 48).

David Harvey's *The Condition of Postmodernity* (1989) sketches some of the many connections between mass media and modern life, and relates both to the various social, political and economic forces which shape (post)modern landscapes. Like the other authors, Harvey stops short of calling television a place, but he gives television a large role in setting the standards of ephemerality, superficiality, and superimposition that are manifested in the landscape. Harvey's analysis even posits that "Reality, it seems, is being shaped to mimic media images" (p. 85), but television is not the primary source of ephemerality, superficiality, and superimposition. "[T]elevision is itself a product of late capitalism and, as such, has to be seen in the context of the promotion of a culture of consumerism" (1989, 61). Harvey thus situates his argument within a historical-materialist perspective:

consumer culture (including entertainment media) creates certain kinds of landscapes, and these landscapes work, through "the politics of distraction," to impose social structure.

While Harvey's concept of "time-space compression" (1989, 240 et seq.) begins to address the issue of the transformation of cultural space, it implies only that the far becomes near; it does not indicate how the near also becomes far. That is, while certain distant places become more accessible and familiar, many near places become less familiar and less accessible (as indicated by Janelle 1973 and Abler 1975). Some complexities of this situation are probed in a fascinating article by Gould (1991).

Denis Cosgrove, Andrew Sayer, David Ley, and others have called for an integration of historical materialism and humanist geography (Kobayashi and Mackenzie 1989, chs. 10, 11, 12). Such an integration must address the central role of mass communication in socioeconomic as well as cultural life in modern societies. To enter into this discussion requires that geographers consider expanding their definitions of place to (at least temporarily) meet the media theorists on common ground. My unconventional use of the term "place" is undertaken in this spirit. By considering television as a place I am not denying the importance of location to the traditional concept of place, but rather pointing out the decreasing importance of location in the structuring of social life and the construction of meaningful human experiences.

Two Problems with Television as Place

The existing geographic studies demonstrate the geographic importance of television, but do not suggest that television is *like* a place or provide a clue to what kind of place it may be like. Research in media theory raises this issue, but does not examine its implications for the meaning of place. In order to span this gap, it is necessary to address two problems: television's apparent lack of boundaries and its ambiguous scale.

If by "television" one means the box in the living room, then its scale seems too small to justify consideration as a geographically important place, and, in any case, the boundary (the surface of the screen) is impermeable

(except by light). If, on the other hand, one means by "television" that complex organization of people, technology and symbols of which the box in the living room is only a tiny part, then the notion of boundaries takes on a very abstract meaning; images come from anywhere and can be seen anywhere, virtually everything is "in" television and the scale becomes unmanageable.

While this uncertainty would seem to prohibit calling television a place, the idea of a place that cannot be physically entered is not entirely foreign to geography. In *Space and Place*, Tuan defines place as a "center of felt value" (1977, 4). He also mentions objects and people as centers of value (18, 138–39). At first consideration the differences between places, persons, and objects seem obvious, but Tuan reveals that they are in fact overlapping categories of experience. He suggests that a parent is a place to his or her young child (19–33). The salient factor here is a strong sentiment of attachment and the enduring presence of the object of attachment; a place need not be physically enter-able or fixed in space.

The degree of emotional attachment that people feel for television is not easily defined. Attachment varies among cultures, between men and women, and in regard to other factors (Newton and Buck 1985; Lull 1988). (It is generally greatest for those with the most social prestige.) Though few people openly discuss television as an important part of their life, formal and informal attempts to forgo television often fail (e.g., see Duggan and Beauchamp 1990). Detachment, rather than attachment, may be the popular conception of the human-television relationship not because people are actually detached, but because television "flatters us for the very boredom and distrust which it inspires in us" (Miller 1986, 194). To the degree that people would feel lost and uncomfortable without television, we may assume, then, that they may be emotionally attached to it. If they are attached to television, it may offer similar opportunities for the experience of place as a loved person or object.³

In everyday speech, "place" and "location" are often used interchangeably. Yet, in everyday life, people often experience places without knowing where they are in terms of a location. Many soldiers who fought in Vietnam were unable to locate Vietnam on a map after

they returned. For them, Vietnam was defined by state of mind (fear, discomfort) and social context (armed conflict), not by location. If television involves us, then that involvement alone may "draw us in," causing us to cross an experiential boundary, if not a physical boundary.

A second concern is scale. While a big object like an ocean liner seems clearly place-like, somehow it seems unjustified to call a small object like a coffee cup a "place." The ability to enter the former and not the latter seems to be the determining factor. But a coffee cup may be thought of as a place, for example, if one vicariously takes the viewpoint of a cockroach. If the inability to enter is part of the problem in considering television as a place, then the ability of viewers to adopt vicarious perspectives and imagine being in the places they see on television may partially solve the problem, at least (to again raise one of the postulates of this paper) if we can consider places as social contexts and centers of meaning and set aside the criterion of location.

A final objection to considering television as place emerges at the junction of semiotics and human geography, that is, in the idea that languages and systems of communication throughout human history have shaped human perception of the world. Even the simplest art forms, for example, cave paintings, have the experiential characteristics sketched above: they involve persons, create emotional attachment, and encourage a vicarious perspective. To see what factors distinguish television from other media is the first task in the analysis of television as a social context.

Television and Social Space

Television and Other Symbolic Systems

Language initially comes "between" people and their immediate surroundings by supplying concepts and distinctions drawn from the past experiences of many people in various places. In language, a particular object becomes merely an instance of an abstract concept—a tree rather than *this* thing (with such and such characteristics)—and therefore a contingent (nonnecessary) attribute of any particular place. Certain types of objects may

be linguistically associated with places (e.g., Norfolk Island Pines) and specific objects may even be named for locations (e.g., the London Bridge). But language, as a system of generalizations, encourages conceptual separation of objects from contexts. The rules underlying language (i.e., grammar), do not restrict any object (a noun) to any particular place (another noun) (see Saussure 1983).

Linguistic thinking, the separation of object and context through generalization, makes society itself possible, and shapes the human-environment interaction in various ways. Language facilitates adaptation to environmental conditions (Tuan 1990, 77–91), the exertion of control over people's actions and other phenomena (Sack 1986, 21), and the acquisition of knowledge (Berger and Luckman 1966). In short, the human experience of place cannot exist without language.

The relationship between place and a *linguistic structure*, such as a story, poem, essay, or book is less clear. Virtually all linguistic structures can function as both social contexts and centers of meaning (to employ the terminology adopted at the outset). People can discuss a book and thereby, in some sense, "occupy" it as a social context. A book, play, poem, or story can also become a center of meaning, and even be experienced subjectively as "another world." Still, a linguistic structure is different from a place in several key respects: First, a linguistic structure is made up of abstract units—words—whereas a place is made up of actual, particular objects, forces and substances.⁴ In the first case, experience transforms the abstract into the concrete while in the second it transforms the concrete into the abstract. Second, a linguistic structure can be reproduced exactly, whereas a place cannot. Third, a linguistic structure can be experienced at various rates, unaffected by interruptions; whereas a place unfolds in its own time and if one leaves a place for a few years, the accumulation of changes is noticeable. These criteria distinguish linguistic structures from places.⁵

Visual images often contain symbolic elements, but are also capable of representing visual reality with great precision. All photographs, since they are mechanically produced, retain much of the concreteness (e.g., shape, color, texture, details) of objects. A photo-

graph of a tree is not simply a picture of "a tree" but a picture of *this* tree; it almost always contains details unique to one and only one particular tree. This direct, mechanical process of representation is why photographs (like x-rays and fingerprints) are extremely useful in identifying people and objects. The phrase "a picture is worth a thousand words" understates the situation.⁶ Pictures differ from "being there" in one important way: they lack the fourth dimension, time. Thus, in regard to the third distinction listed above, pictures are no more place-like than linguistic structures. Pictures also differ from places in that they are reproducible.

Radio eliminates the third distinction, but it is unplace-like insofar as it depends on words and can be reproduced. Most important, perhaps, radio can, at best, only suggest visual images. The emergence of television essentially completed the elimination of the second and third distinctions. While both the talk and the music on radio could be considered abstract—the former for reasons already discussed, the latter by its very nature—television's moving pictures were concrete and related mechanically to the visual world. Film had already combined photography's concreteness with a temporal dimension. Television disassociated the moving image from a finite set of viewing locations (movie theaters) and allowed the moving image to create its own sense of place.

While television uses abstract units (written and spoken words), it depends heavily on visuals and nonverbal sounds. In this regard it surpasses other media in overcoming the first distinction outlined above; efforts to reduce television to a set of discrete meaningful units along the line of words or "semes" have not succeeded. In regard to the second and third distinction, television is also more place-like than other media. While television *programs* can be reproduced through the use of video cassette recorders (VCRs), television as a whole (comprised of a multitude of channels, many of which broadcast twenty-four hours a day) cannot be reproduced. Although VCRs allow persons to view television at their own *time*, by "capturing a piece" and replaying it, the *rate* of displaying the "piece" is essentially invariable; few people watch a whole program in slow motion, fast forward, or reverse. In

addition, this captured segment is not "television," it is a program.

One piece of evidence to support the contention that television is less abstract than other communication media is that it is accessible to those on the peripheries of the linguistic system. Two-year-olds, not yet able to read and limited in verbal abilities, are able to recognize TV actors, discriminate between ads and programs (preferring ads), and learn complex activity sequences from television actors (Lemish 1987, 42–54). Similarly, television is often used by foreigners to learn English. This is possible because the meaning of words can be inferred from the moving pictures' clear representation of actions and situations.

My discussion thus far has assumed a point which I should mention explicitly. Although television can be thought of as many private objects, each within the private space of a home, it can also be thought of as a single "monolithic" object which people view from their various perspectives. Thinking of television monolithically is, in fact, very common. This is what we mean when we say that "TV is good" (or bad, or boring, or violent, etc.). Though justification for this monolithic view of television is weakening, as cable services, the diffusion of the VCR and video-tape rental services, and remote control devices undermine the monopoly of the three broadcast networks, people continue to speak of television as a single entity. The monolithic perspective is plausible because each set is *potentially* tuned to programs visible on millions of other screens. Furthermore, programs tend to reflect many of the same assumptions and values, and, within the various genres, have similar story lines and character types. By television, then, I do not mean the part but the whole.

Realization of television's uniquely place-like character has been sporadic. Events such as the Vietnam War, the assassination of John F. Kennedy, the first human step on the moon, and the Persian Gulf War have drawn attention to television's ability to serve as a shared social context on a national scale. Between these events, the role of television did not change, but awareness of that role was dimmed. The sheer number and diversity of persons in the social contexts created by television, while contributing to its place-like character, also

increases the tension between physical place and television. This tension disguises the similarity between the two. This tension can also be seen in either a positive light, as in McLuhan's concept of the electronic "global village," or a negative light, as in Meyrowitz's *No Sense of Place* (1985).

A further aspect of traditional conceptions of place can be brought into the discussion at this point. While location can not be meaningfully applied to television, position can. In the terminology of the "screen theory" school of media criticism, a text "positions" viewers when it shapes events to correspond to a particular social group's values and perceptions (see MacCabe 1981). In the case of television, this perspective is usually white, Christian, middle- to upper-class, and, above all, consumerist. Thus, television looks at the world from the social position of the politically and economically dominant group.⁷ It is not certain how strongly television "positions" viewers. There is disagreement concerning the degree to which the television text is "open" to various interpretations. This confusion may be reduced by again considering the meaning of place.

A place is traditionally a *position* in both space and society. Geometry and social structure, physical position and social position, traditionally come together in place. In the pre-modern world, physical position and social position were inextricably wedded: where one lived, ate, shopped, socialized and worshipped indicated one's status and limited one's view of society. In the modern world, however, physical position does not have this strong association with social position. Rapid transportation, the regime of flexible accumulation, and electronic communication all weaken the links between place and social position. These same phenomena become means to social status and provide their own perspectives on society. Consequently, to say that television "positions" viewers is not necessarily to imply a deterministic relationship, because "position" in its most concrete sense, the geographic, is now fragmented and relative.

An idea similar to "positioning" is expressed in discussions of television's "centrality" (see Williams 1974, 53; Ellis 1982, 227–36; Fiske and Hartley 1976, 86–87). The idea of centrality

links positioning with cultural popularity and social centralization: Fiske and Hartley (1978, 86) write:

television is one of the most highly centralized institutions in modern society. This is not only a result of commercial monopoly or government control, it is also a response to the culture's felt need for a common centre, to which the television message always refers. Its centralization speaks to all members of our highly fragmented society.

In Williams and Ellis, there is a similar coming together of television's popularity and the idea that television arises from centralized forms of social integration. These two assertions together suggest a peculiar kind of positioning, one which arises through a union of public acceptance and the expression of power. Historically, we find monumental architecture has filled this role.

Television as a Monument

Churches, temples, government buildings, and other monumental structures give a visual and/or auditory focus to the experience of living in a community, allow people to be united in space either vicariously or in actuality, and define here and there, not necessarily by demarcating definite boundaries, but by forming a nucleus for social life and for peoples' construction of meaningful life experiences (Barthes 1979; Giedion 1964, 343–48; Gimpel 1980; Tuan 1982). Though not necessarily sacred, monuments embody symbolism that is linked to important social values, and, though highly visible, may seldom be occupied on a regular basis. Occupation may be restricted to certain times, to one or two persons, or even to the dead.

The extent to which earlier structures differ from each other is no less radical than the extent to which they all differ from television. In regard to physical form, the differences are overwhelming. In regard to social function, we can see much in television that recalls the older structures. Television can be seen and heard by virtually any member of a modern society; it allows people to rise above the chaos of daily life and survey the world from

a position of omniscience; it separates one class of people—politicians, entertainers, and public figures—from the rest of people, and puts them in a privileged position where they can be seen and emulated and yet remain separate from society. Of course statehouses and churches built of stone and iron still tower at the center of many cities, giving concrete expression to the notion of centrality. But increasingly these forms must compete with a form that surpasses them in centrality and visibility. It is interesting that television has begun to absorb both church and government chambers, through “televangelism” and C-SPAN, a cable channel devoted to live political broadcasting.

Television is both more visible and more sheltered from the periphery than is the case with any previous form. To extend the spatial analogy, it is as if viewers were on one side and performers, politicians, and “personalities” on the other side of a transparent boundary of indeterminate and varying thickness.

While it is easy to survey the world from television's vantage point, it is quite difficult to appear on television. *What* is on TV is distant from most persons in space; *who* is on TV is remote from most persons in social power. The prerequisites to appear on TV include wealth, beauty, authority, talent and luck. Any of these, in large amounts, confers the power to cross the thick, yet transparent barrier⁸ between on and off television. Further power is conferred by appearing on television. While this power transforms the living into stars, it transforms the dead into symbols. Divorced from the original referents (persons), they become like the “simulacra” described by Jean Baudrillard (1983). All that remains are purified embodiments of certain character traits or virtues, not unlike gods of the Greek pantheon: John Kennedy becomes courage; Lucille Ball, rambunctiousness; Janice Joplin, freedom.

The historical trend in monumental structures has been from solidity to ephemerality, from the mass to the open network, from substance to light, from a focus on death to a focus on life, from the sacred to the mundane, from one occupant to many. In this broad sweep of history, television appears as a logical development. One obvious difference from architectural structures is that television

is not static. Whereas all of the structures mentioned are notable for their permanence and changelessness, television is noted for its newness and constant change. Paradoxically, both permanence and constant change stand in a similar relation to time: both achieve what Peter Berger refers to as “the transcendence of erosive time” (1967, 37). The decomposition of a pyramid is scarcely visible within a human lifetime. Television—if we mean the flow of images from multiple sources, rather than the individual receivers—does not decompose at all. Thus, if we can assume that permanence reflects a basic human desire to overcome erosion, to create something immortal, it might be said that television is an improvement on monumental architecture.

One of the most important types of erosion that can be transcended is human erosion, that is, people’s attempts to mark, mar, and destroy. War, graffiti, and vandalism all take arms against buildings. The resultant damage becomes a visible display of disagreement, a contradiction of the ideology of those whose authority raised the monument (Gottdiener 1986a, 206). To build in marble is, among other things, to silence dissent. Throwing a brick through a TV screen has no effect on what is seen on any other screen. Television’s resistance to violent opposition thus is quite remarkable. This resistance can only be overcome by terrorism, because the immediacy and personal quality of terrorism virtually guarantee television coverage. If we view terrorism as graffiti aimed at television, then it is interesting that television has means of cleansing itself of this graffiti. Many of the conventions of news reporting “claw back” the meanings of insurrection, revolution, and terrorism by reiterating the ideologies of the dominant position and by organizing and arranging information that could potentially discredit the dominant perspective (Fiske and Hartley 1978, 87).

The monolithic perspective, which I have elaborated by comparison with monumental architecture, must be balanced with an appreciation of the variations in the audience (Fiske 1987; Morley 1986), because cultural and personal factors shape each interaction between a person and a television. The next section will reveal the symbolic opposition that underlies variations in the audience.

Television and Symbolic Space

Audiences: Inside versus Outside, a First View

Martin Esslin makes the seminal observation that “Television is the *one* factor that practically all the individuals in this society have in common. It is the unifying substratum of experience”⁹ (1982, 54). Television can provide, at the nominal level of “watching television” (that is, below the variety of its genres) the shared experience of a particular technology: the screen, channel selection, the possibility of viewing distant places simultaneously with thousands or millions of others, the power of an on/off switch. Beyond this the experience becomes somewhat ambiguous.

The range of visibility of many programs extends far beyond the society that produces them and that they help to define. Shows such as *Dallas*, *Dynasty*, *The A-Team*, and *The Muppets* have, or had, global audiences (Ang 1985, 1988; Dayan and Katz 1985; Collins 1988). Audiences often take a different “viewing stance” when watching foreign programs from the one they take when watching indigenous programs. This fact allows Dayan and Katz to divide the audience of a particular program into outsiders (called “secondary audiences”) and insiders (called “primary audiences”) (1985, 61). This insider/outsider dichotomy results in very different readings of the same audiovisual images. In television coverage of a British royal wedding,

secondary audiences . . . are also witnessing a ritual, a ritual formally similar to that watched by television primary audiences but semantically quite different. The British watch royalty. Foreigners watch England (Dayan and Katz 1985, 61)

Dayan and Katz find that secondary audiences tend to relate their viewing experience primarily to the geographic origin, state, or cultural group from which a program originates—seeing the program as emblematic of *them* as opposed to *us*—and imposing cultural prejudices on the viewing experience. Primary audiences, on the other hand, tend to see programs as particular aspects, views, or segments of a culture (their own), or merely as fantasy, rather than as an image of their own culture in toto. For the primary audience, the

program is an emblem of a *them* that is part of *us* (Katz and Dayan 1985). This distinction partially breaks down when primary audiences view a state ritual, such as an inauguration or the Olympics, which attempts to forge a unified sense of *us*. Nevertheless, large segments of the primary audience, at least in the U.S., view even these events as performances of *them*.

The physical region occupied by the primary audience varies with each program. The boundary between primary and secondary viewers is complex and constantly shifting since insideness and outsideness ultimately lie in the interpretive strategies of individual viewers. Liebes and Katz find that some ethnic groups in Israel (kibbutz members) tend to perceive the program *Dallas* much like insiders, while others (Russian Jews) perceive the program as outsiders—giving greater credence to the Americanness of the program than to the program's explicit qualities (1988, 116). This interpretive orientation (not to be confused with the TV text's positioning of the viewer mentioned earlier) is not strictly dependent on viewer location, neither is it independent of location. Villages, and even neighborhoods, may orient themselves differently in regard to a particular program than their neighbors. Herbert Gans's study of Boston's "urban villagers" reveals a neighborhood in an American city that positions itself outside of the culture it sees on television even though it is politically, spatially, and even culturally integrated into that culture in many ways (1982, chap. 9).

Simply stated, television audiences are theoretically divisible into an inside and an outside audience, although the boundary is empirically and conceptually difficult to determine. "Inside" and "outside," here, correspond to perceptual strategies. It will now be fruitful to return to a more common conception of inside and outside—the state of being physically enclosed or excluded by a structure's walls.

Visible but Separate: Inside versus Outside, a Second View

Architecture's most basic function is to provide shelter. A house has a definite boundary articulated by walls and windows which keep

out drafts and rain. Inside and outside are separated by this boundary. Monumental architecture also defines inside and outside in this way. The Eiffel Tower not only defines an ambiguous and fluctuating district of visibility but also contains, within its physical structure, a certain volume of space. In most monuments, this second function is subordinate to the first. A person standing on the ground between two "legs" of the Eiffel Tower can look straight up and see nothing but sky; if it is raining, the Eiffel Tower provides scant shelter for its vast size. The enclosed elevator, restaurants, and gift shops enclose space and keep out the rain, but the decks themselves, the stairway, and the rest of the tower are not clearly inside or outside. Most of the structure comprises a thick and ambiguous intermediate zone between inside and outside.

The history of monumental architecture is largely the evolution of a thick and complex boundary zone. A pyramid's boundary between inside and outside is many meters thick. Gothic cathedrals have similarly deep boundaries; though the actual walls are thin, stained glass windows allow light to penetrate, bringing part of the outside in. Pyramids are absurdly inefficient, in terms of mass per interior volume, while cathedrals are fairly efficient. As means for enclosing heat and excluding cold, cathedrals are inefficient. In either case, the function of shelter is subordinate to the symbolic separation of inside and out.

In some cases, a thick and inefficient boundary layer between inside and out serves an important symbolic function by emphasizing the importance of what is inside. Church walls demarcate the boundary between sacred and profane space. The mass of the pyramid also separates sacred from profane. The Eiffel Tower's thick boundary between in and out does not appear to serve this function: the interior spaces do not house a god-king, but rather paying visitors; the world is not symbolized by, but rather displayed by the tower. This does not mean that the tower is symbolically insignificant.

In a society where power over human affairs is more highly valued than sacred power, the ability to survey may be quite important (see Barthes 1979; Foucault 1977). Public access to a place that confers omniscience strongly symbolizes the ideals embodied in "Liberté, Égalité, Fraternité." It also symbolizes universal

access to knowledge (see de Certeau 1985, 123). Though not sacred, the Eiffel Tower concretizes (Norberg-Schulz 1980) some of the most important shared symbols and values of its culture.

An even more easily accessible vantage point, and one which provides a semblance of omniscience not just of a city, but of the known universe, is television. Interestingly, the historical trend in architectural boundary zones has been from solidity to ephemerality (as noted above in regard to the evolution of monumental structures themselves), from opaque to transparent, from exclusive to inclusive. This evolution cuts across the traditional distinctions between sacred and secular architecture; and, again, television fits the general trend.

The connections I have made between television and sacred places suggest a simplistic interpretation: that television is the modern equivalent of the temple or cathedral. In fact, only certain functions of these structures can be associated with television. To claim equivalence, much more evidence would be needed and also an objective judgment about what aspects of society in fact constitute religion. Though the idea that modern society is secular may be a myth, (Luckman 1983) there is great difficulty in assessing the religious elements in one's own culture. "Curiously," Luckman notes, "few scholars hesitate to acknowledge the presence of religion in certain instances where such a label would not mean much, if anything, to the members of the societies under scrutiny, with one exception, that of modern industrial societies, especially Western industrial societies." This he attributes to "the popular and sociological myths of secularization and the firm association of religion with its traditionally dominant institutional forms" (1983, 164). Thus, the fact that churches are declining in importance is not necessarily a sign that religiosity is declining in importance (see also Park 1967, 109). As Luckman suggests, religiosity is integrated throughout society in a majority of non-Western cultures, past and present, not segregated in churches. Marx's concept of commodity fetishism indicates that capitalism itself may be based on magical or quasi-religious attitudes toward the products of industry. Finally, there is Robert Bellah's description of parades and other modern national spectacles as "civic

rituals" (1970). Television's role in encouraging consumption (e.g., Schiller 1989), its ubiquity, and its involvement in national spectacles, suggest that it might be considered analogous to a sacred structure by an objective onlooker from outside Western culture. Our casual treatment of the medium does not necessarily invalidate the idea that television is sacred, since many previous cultures, including medieval Europe (Gimpel 1983, 38, 41), treated their sacred places quite casually. Although television is often banal, it is unfortunately true that modern culture worships the banal, not only through the devotion of time to TV viewing, but also through the celebration of heroes such as the cartoon cat Garfield and the cartoon boy Bart Simpson.

The issues I have raised here cannot be resolved without a detailed discussion of the role of sacred places in the meaning-making processes of societies (see Berger et al. 1973, esp. p. 67; Berger and Luckman 1966; Berger 1967; and Luckman 1983). The fact that television is a commercial medium (even public TV stations rely on corporate sponsorship and are subject to market forces in their search for funds), in no way *intended* to function as a sacred or even a quasi-sacred artifact, should not be forgotten. What is most interesting in regard to these issues is the social role of television in defining the status of persons.

Recent years have brought a growing conviction among media theorists in the U.S. that television serves a religious function in modern society. Titles have appeared such as "Media: The Second God" (Schwartz 1981), "Worship at the Video Altar" (Goethals 1981), and "Six O'clock Prayers: TV news as Pop Religion" (Richardson 1975). Others have written about "Television Myth and Culture" (Silverstone 1988), "Myth, Chronicle, and Story: Exploring the Narrative Qualities of the News" (Bird and Dardenne 1988), and "Television Myth and Ritual: The Role of Substantive Meaning and Spatiality" (Hoover 1988). Information itself has been shown to have a "mythic" dimension in modern society (Woodward 1980). Although many of these arguments are vague, some of the assertions are insightful, as when Jack Richardson observes that the news is "more an act of communion than communication" (1975, 34).

The association of television with religious structures receives additional support from a

strange quarter. The anthropologist Gary Granzberg has found that the Cree of Central Canada, when introduced to television, called it by the same name as their traditional religious structure. TV was seen as:

the West's version of a traditional technology that had long provided a very similar form of education and entertainment. This was the shaman's conjuring tent in which a seance could be held with dead people, spirits, or people living some distance away, and in which news from all over the world could be obtained, even knowledge of the future or hidden things (Granzberg 1985, 323).

Towards a Synthesis of Inside versus Outside 1 and Inside versus Outside 2

I have described an inside and an outside audience that orient themselves experientially in complementary ways relative to television content. I have also described an inside and outside corresponding to the separation between those who are seen on television and those who watch television. Several rather complex situations arise from the combination of these two factors. Inside (primary) audiences are more likely than outside (secondary) audiences to find their values supported by what appears on the screen. Outside audiences may disregard the images of foreign stars (dead and alive) or appropriate them for alien purposes.¹⁰

In countries that import large amounts of television programming, that is, virtually all countries except for the U.S. (Wete 1988, 144), the desire for sovereignty is often expressed in relation to television, which is seen as a hegemonic tool. International debates over communication flow lie at the heart of global tensions, though this fact is seldom recognized in the U.S. In the period following the expulsion of Israel from UNESCO, delegates became increasingly hostile towards U.S. efforts to guarantee countries the right to communicate via foreign mass media. This controversy illustrates that in regard to television, the U.S. perception differs sharply from the majority of world perception: the U.S. sees access to foreign television as guaranteeing the free flow of information while most other countries see access as an open door to American values and beliefs. Controversy in UNESCO over the First World's dom-

ination of news reporting and news dissemination in the Third World escalated until 1984, when the U.S. withdrew from the organization (Wete 1988; Coate 1988; Hajnal 1983).

Debates have arisen recently about the effect of programs such as *Dallas* on European culture (Ang 1988; Collins 1988). Since American programs have become quite popular in Europe, there is fear of "contamination: the fundamentally *political* concern over the defilement and, eventually, the elimination of European cultural identity" (Ang 1988, 72). Economic, political and ideological hegemony shade into each other as images of consumption and advertisements increase the desire for goods, which in turn encourages the abandonment of traditional lifestyles and world views (Carpenter 1973). I suspect that what is at issue goes deeper than politics, to the social construction of reality—a process which might be called ideological or even spiritual. Berger et al. argue that,

Through mass publication, motion pictures, radio and television, the cognitive and normative definitions of reality invented in the city are rapidly diffused throughout the entire society. To be linked to these media is to be involved in the continuing urbanization of consciousness (1973, 67).

I believe that an understanding of the global effect of television will only begin to emerge when there is an appreciation of the variation among audience stances and of the possibility that television has deep, conflicting significance for both inside and outside audience segments.

Conclusion

I have elaborated on the idea that television is a social context and a center of meaning. My intent has been to begin to explore the separation of social and physical contexts in modern life. Though television lacks a definable location, it serves various social and symbolic functions previously served by places: sensory communion, social congregation, the attribution of value to persons and objects, and the definition of an "us" and a "them."

Several factors complicate the picture I have painted. As Abler's work suggests (1975b), interpersonal media such as the telephone, the postal service, fax machines, and com-

puter networks undermine the monolithic characteristics of television. Also, the monumental architecture of previous eras obviously remains visible and significant in modern landscapes. In addition, skyscrapers vigorously assert their presence. Other cultural forms, such as the shopping mall and the school, vie for a central cultural "position," as well.

Of all these factors, probably only the first—interpersonal media—seriously challenges television's centrality. Though pyramids, temples, churches, and other monuments remain in the landscape, through careful tending they become museum pieces (Relph 1976, 101–03) or civic trophies, their significance undermined by electronic social contexts. Skyscrapers are experienced less as places by the general public than as obstacles; despite their glass walls, private ownership renders them opaque and virtually meaningless. The shopping mall has from its inception existed in symbiotic relationship with the mass media; in effect, the mall provides the accessories for a lifestyle shown on the media, and, as Gottdiener points out: "the sign systems of the mall, . . . are mere extensions of the content of advertising which appears elsewhere, such as magazines, television, newspapers, and the like" (1986b, 299). And what little social life goes on inside the mall is highly regulated and even less interesting than television. Finally (and most discouragingly for those involved in education), school must compete with another "curriculum"—television—and the attitude of students that "anything worth learning can take the form of an entertainment" (Postman 1985, 154).

Television does something that other products of modern culture are increasingly unable to do: it stands at the center. Television expresses some of the same human motivations that led to the building of monumental forms, but in a modern world where "all that is solid melts into air."¹¹ Furthermore, the very characteristics of modern architecture, "Fiction, fragmentation, collage, and eclecticism, all suffused with a sense of ephemerality and chaos" (Harvey 1989, 98), are eminently typical of television (see Fiske 1987).

This study has examined only a few of the place-like characteristics of television. Further studies are needed to probe other aspects of place and to examine the possible relevance of traditional geographical conceptions of

environment, world, and space in regard to television. An understanding of these would complement many of the concepts developed here.

Acknowledgments

I thank Yi-Fu Tuan, Joshua Meyrowitz, John Fiske, and especially Robert Sack for the guidance and criticism they provided while I developed these ideas. I also thank Karina Martens, Leonora Ko, and Drew Ross for valuable assistance. None of them is responsible for the arguments or conclusions in this paper.

Notes

1. In 1967 Robert Park observed the separation of human environments into the physical and the social, noting that "the environment in which human beings live is . . . largely made up of the experience and memories and the acquired habits of the people who have preceded them. . . . This experience and these memories—crystallized and embodied in tradition, in custom, and in folk-ways—constitute the social, as distinguished from the biological, environment" (100). My analysis reflects the three-fold division proposed by Robert Sack (1988, 1989).
2. Tuan does raise the question in some of his lectures whether a book might not be a kind of place. In *Between Space and Time*, Harvey writes "[T]here is still an insistent urge to look for roots in a world where image streams accelerate and become more and more placeless (unless the television and video screen can properly be regarded as a place)" (1990, 427).
3. The intersection between emotion and place-experience is a field that deserves greater attention; at this point, assertions must be based more on speculation than empirical evidence.
4. Our attempts to understand these objects, forces, and substances depend on abstraction. Even the terms "objects," "forces," "substances" carve up concrete reality in a certain way, and serve only to point towards a concrete reality which shows no such arbitrary divisions.
5. Oral histories and legends do evolve over time and therefore may be slightly more "place-like" than the other linguistic structures.
6. Roland Barthes (1982) presents in painstaking detail the various ways a photograph conveys meaning. His intent is to argue against seeing photographs as simply "the way it is" and hence free of ideology. John Berger and Stuart Hall support this position. These views are very useful, but do not invalidate my observations. In the terminology of semiotics, the distinction I make is between an iconic, or "motivated," sign in which the signifier represents the shape or some other characteristic of the signified, and

an arbitrary, unmotivated sign in which the relationship is purely conventional (see Fiske and Hartley 1978, 38–40). Moving photographs, film and video, are intrinsically the least arbitrary symbolic forms devised thus far, though an arbitrary, unmotivated component is certainly present. This argument is not in any way a denial of the symbolic and “coded” nature of television sequences. For two good descriptions of the grammar of television’s image sequences, see Fiske and Hartley 1978, and Ellis 1982.

7. Giddens uses the terms in a somewhat similar way. In his lexicon, positioning is the process by which agents are made to behave in a way that reflects their socially recognized identity. While “signification, domination, and legitimation” characterize both kinds of positioning, Giddens applies the term to social action rather than cultural products (1984, 83–92).
8. My use of the term “transparent” here is not meant to deny the fundamentally constructed nature of television image flows, but is rather an attempt to capture the spatial sense of the experience of viewing television.
9. Many scholars, particularly those influenced by European marxian thought, would take issue with this statement, arguing that capitalism itself, rather than television, is the unifying substratum of capitalist society. I believe that capitalism as a singular and monolithic entity exists only in theory. At the level of *experience*, however, capitalism is anything but a singular shared experience. It is partly because capitalism shatters the commonality and communality of modern life—producing myriad intersecting and yet idiosyncratic sequences of movement through an environment that has also become highly fragmented—that something like television is needed. Television constitutes a field of shared experience where increasing specialization and social differentiation can be temporarily transcended. The importance of television in communist and socialist societies suggests that industrialization, specialization, urbanization, and bureaucratization are as important as capitalism in spurring the growth of television use.
10. In the early 1980s, French youth used images of Marilyn Monroe, Elvis Presley, and James Dean to support lifestyles significantly different from those ever prevalent in the U.S.
11. This phrase, taken from Marx, is the title of a book by Marshall Berman and a recurrent theme in discussions of postmodernity (e.g., see Ley 1989, 44; Sack 1988, 651; Harvey 1989, 11).

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Submitted 1/90, revised 2/91, accepted 5/91.